Victoria) with 18 sailors returned to Seville in 1522. Vittoria was the first ship that ever circumnavigated the world.

Turks, French, English, and Germans had not yet realised the significance of the new sea routes to Asia. They were yet to understand the political importance of the European discovery of America. Hernan Cortes, a Spanish Conquistador, with a mere handful of men conquered the Empire of Mexico for Spain. Pizarro crossed the Isthmus of Panama (1530) and subjugated another country Peru, destroying the Inca Empire in south America.

Other Important European Expeditions

Following in the footsteps of the Portuguese and the Spanish seafarers, other European countries started exploring the world. John Cabot, an Italian explorer, was commissioned by England to find new lands across the globe. On his voyage he saw Canada and made it an English colony. Giovanni da Verrazano, another Italian, explored the lands for the French. He annexed provinces for the French in eastern Canada. An English explorer named Henry Hudson wanted to find the passage from North America to the Pacific Ocean. Though he failed in his initiative, he explored the region which now bears his name – Hudson River.

Catastrophic Impact of Spanish Arms: Although the Aztecs had superior numbers, with firearms and steel blades at his disposal, just one Spaniard could annihilate dozens or even hundreds of opponents: "On a sudden, they speared and thrust people into shreds," wrote one indigenous chronicler, a witness to the terrifying impact of European arms. "Others were beheaded in one swipe... Others tried to run in vain from the butchery, their innards falling from them and entangling their very feet." A smallpox epidemic outbreak weakened the Aztec while giving Cortes time to regroup, resume fighting and finally emerge victorious.

Due to the rising competition from England, there was conflict between Spain and England. Francis Drake annexed California region for the English, despite protests from Spain. This led to war between the two nations. In 1588 King Philip II of Spain sent an armada or Spanish fleet of 130 vessels and 31,000 soldiers to invade England. However, the English with their easily manoeuvrable fleet easily destroyed the Spanish Armada. This marked the rise of the British as an important power in modern world.

10.3 Commercial Revolution

The Renaissance and the Reformation were accompanied by fundamental economic changes. The series of economic changes, making the transition from the semi-static, localised, non-profit economy of the late Middle Ages to the dynamic, world-wide, capitalistic regime of the fourteenth and succeeding centuries is known as the Commercial Revolution. This Revolution was gradual.

The causes of the beginning of the Revolution were (a) the capture of Mediterranean trade by the Italian cities; (b) the development of a flourishing trade between Italian cities and the merchants of Hanseatic League (a merchant guild) in northern Europe; (c) introduction of coins such as the *duca* of Venice and the *florin* of Florence; (d) the accumulation of surplus earned out of trading, shipping and mining enterprises; (e) the demand for war materials and the encouragement given by the new monarchs to the development of commerce in order to create more taxable wealth. The combination of these factors along with the stimulus given by the voyages resulting in Spanish and Portuguese merchants to discover a new route to the Orient, independent of Italian control, paved the way for Commercial Revolution.

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